

Phase 1: Planning for the School Year *What do I want to notice, build, and prepare?*

The core question across all planning: Where are my students most likely to connect naturally to this course — and where might they feel distance from it?

CULTURAL COMPETENCY

- ▶ Revisit first-week norms: do they make room for different communication styles and personalities?
- ▶ Audit your curriculum for "single story" moments — where could you add complexity, disagreement, or additional voices?
- ▶ Expand participation options: written reflection before discussion, small groups before whole class, visual/oral/collaborative response modes
- ▶ Look for places where abstract content could connect more directly to students' communities or current events

TEACHING & LEARNING

- ▶ Lessen students' cognitive load: simplify crowded slides, multi-step instructions, or over-complicated routines can drain mental energy from actual learning
- ▶ Plan for retrieval: which core concepts deserve repeated interleaving (returning to the concepts) across the semester?
- ▶ Build in moments to model expert thinking — confusion, revision, troubleshooting — not just polished performance
- ▶ Design for revision: do students have structured opportunities to rethink, recover, and reflect on mistakes?

AI & STUDENT WORK

- ▶ Test your own assignments in ChatGPT or Gemini — see where AI produces shallow but convincing work
- ▶ Clarify your AI use expectations explicitly: when is AI appropriate for brainstorming vs. generating analysis?
- ▶ Design tasks that are difficult to shortcut with AI: live discussion, presentations, local observation, explaining reasoning, process evaluation, reflection tied to lived experience
- ▶ Plan at least one activity where students critique or fact-check AI output
- ▶ For those assignments that 1) AI can do well and 2) are important for students to do on their own, consider how you can effectively prevent AI use
- ▶ For assignments in which AI is allowed, consider how students will document and reflect on their use

FLEX BLOCKS & D.C. OPPORTUNITIES

- ▶ Identify which local sites genuinely deepen course themes — not just interesting, but conceptually connected
- ▶ Design pre-visit preparation so students arrive with meaningful questions.
- ▶ Encourage active documentation: sketching, interviewing, photographing, mapping.
- ▶ [Build reflection in while the experience is fresh](#): What surprised you? What felt more complicated after?

Phase 2: School-Year Check-Ins

During the semester — What's actually happening? What patterns am I noticing?

The core question: Am I relying on impressions about engagement, or do I have actual evidence of how students are participating and learning?

CULTURAL COMPETENCY

- ▶ Track who is speaking: ask a colleague to observe, or notice who contributes first, most, or only in certain formats
- ▶ Notice whether students engage complexity — do they feel safe asking difficult questions or exploring disagreement?
- ▶ Check your own expectations: are you challenging all students equally, or unintentionally protecting some from productive struggle?
- ▶ When bias or assumptions surface in discussion, slow down — these moments can become learning opportunities rather than disciplinary ones

TEACHING & LEARNING

- ▶ Use small assessments as feedback for you to guide instruction: entrance tickets, exit slips, retrieval activities — let evidence drive pacing
- ▶ Make thinking visible: narrate how you approach confusion, revise writing, or troubleshoot problems
- ▶ Revisit mistakes together — ask students to explain what went wrong and why, not just what the correct answer is
- ▶ Shift discussions toward student-led meaning-making: can students ask one another follow-up questions?

AI & STUDENT WORK

- ▶ Experiment with AI alongside students — model how to question, verify, and compare AI output to stronger human thinking
- ▶ Revisit assignments that may now be too easy to automate; add classroom-specific references, discussion connections, or live components
- ▶ Have students fact-check AI: identify inaccuracies, oversimplifications, missing context, bias, or hallucination
- ▶ Reiterate expectations periodically — clarify the difference between AI as support vs. AI as substitution

FLEX BLOCKS & D.C. OPPORTUNITIES

- ▶ Ask: have I protected time for reflection after experiences - even on the bus ride home?
- ▶ Are students documenting moments that connect directly to class concepts — or just going through the motions?
- ▶ Are local experts being used meaningfully, with student presentations/questions prepared in advance?
- ▶ Build in collaborative tasks during trips so students process together, not just individually

Phase 3: End-of-Semester Reflection

Looking back — What actually happened? What do I want to carry forward?

The core question: What kinds of growth did I actually see in students — and which of my choices contributed to that growth?

CULTURAL COMPETENCY

- ▶ Look for evidence of deeper thinking: are students asking more thoughtful questions, engaging multiple perspectives, or connecting course material to broader social questions?
- ▶ Review student work with colleagues — look for recurring strengths and gaps, and identify where expectations may unintentionally advantage some students
- ▶ Reflect on your own assumptions: were there students you misunderstood early on? What shifted your thinking?
- ▶ Consider belonging: did students feel able to participate authentically? Were there students who remained peripheral or invisible?

TEACHING & LEARNING

- ▶ Study retention: which ideas stayed with students? Which disappeared after initial instruction?
- ▶ Reflect on “healthy struggle”: did students become more willing to struggle productively as the semester went on?
- ▶ Examine metacognition: could students accurately identify their strengths and weaknesses? Could they explain their own thinking?
- ▶ Look for coherence: where did the curriculum feel connected and cumulative — and where did it feel fragmented?

AI & STUDENT WORK

- ▶ Identify what still felt meaningful: seminars, oral defenses, in-class writing, labs, collaborative projects, field-based work
- ▶ Which assignments produced authentic thinking? Which now feel too easy to automate or produced flat, generic student work?
- ▶ Reflect on AI transparency: did students understand expectations? Did conversations reduce secrecy rather than increase it? How useful (for you and the students) were the students’ documentation and reflection on their AI use?
- ▶ Consider where AI genuinely helped: tutoring, accessibility, confidence — and how to refine those supports next year

FLEX BLOCKS & D.C. OPPORTUNITIES

- ▶ Look for real transfer: did students reference flex block experiences organically in later work and discussions?
- ▶ Identify the strongest experiences — which locations or speakers generated the best questions and deepest conversations?
- ▶ Reflect on student ownership: were they active or passive? Did trips build confidence and curiosity?
- ▶ Note logistical adjustments for next year: timing, workload, interdisciplinary connections, debrief structure

Quick-Reference: Reflective Questions by Phase

Use these across all four focus areas to guide ongoing professional reflection

Summer Planning	Summer Planning
Where will students connect — and where might they feel distance?	Do my classroom norms make room for different communication styles?
Which parts of my curriculum still present a single narrative?	Are there places where students could help shape expectations?
Have I tested my assignments in AI tools?	What kinds of thinking do I most want students to practice themselves?
Which D.C. sites genuinely deepen my course themes?	Have I built pre-visit preparation and post-visit reflection?
Where could participation be more varied and inclusive?	Where could content connect more directly to students' lived realities?

School-Year Check-Ins	School-Year Check-Ins
Who is participating comfortably, and who is still finding their footing?	When students struggle, do I know whether the issue is content, confidence, or workload?
Am I relying on impressions, or do I have actual evidence of engagement?	Are mistakes being treated as useful information?
Have I revisited AI expectations recently?	Are students connecting flex block experiences to classroom learning?
Are flex blocks producing active investigators or passive visitors?	Am I challenging all students equally, or protecting some from struggle?

End-of-Semester Reflection	End-of-Semester Reflection
What kinds of growth did I actually observe?	Which classroom routines genuinely supported learning vs. only felt productive?
Which assignments produced authentic thinking and how did I know?	How did my own thinking or teaching shift this semester?
Did students become more willing to take intellectual risks?	Were there students I misunderstood — and what changed?
Did flex blocks deepen understanding over time?	What will I refine, deepen, or rethink for next year?
